

How Technology Abuse Consumes us

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Social media, phones, and iPads—what do all these things have in common? For me, it's that their overuse results in negative effects for you, your relationships, and your kids. That's what I plan to illustrate in this essay for the purpose of helping you decide for yourself whether or not you could have more peace and joy by adopting different technology habits.

One of the most common abuses of technology in most people's lives is social media addiction. According to Sherer, J. (n.d., para. 3.), social media addiction is defined as “Problematic and compulsive use of social media; an obsessive need to check and update social media platforms, often resulting in problems in functioning and disrupted real-world relationships.” Now that already sounds concerning, but there are still more negative effects to social media. According to (Johnson & Murnan, 2025; Bounds, 2024) the other adverse effects of social media are: Negative body image, depression, sleep problems, eyestrain, lower self-esteem, increased anxiety, being more than three times as likely to feel socially isolated, and more. Now you may say that all might be true for those who are addicted to social media, but you only use social media to keep up with friends and family. In fact Johnson, J., & Murnan, A. (2025) also stated

“A 2022 review of past studies found that knowing how to use technologies such as instant messaging apps decreased feelings of isolation in older adults. It may be that people's motivations for using technology — and how they use it — affect whether they feel more or less connected to others.” (para. 21.)

So social media can be a tool to help you stay in touch with friends and family. However, it's also just as prone to basically ruin our relationships as well as our mental, emotional, and

physical well-being. It's important to stay aware and vigilant of what motivates you to open your social media app.

Something else to stay aware of is your screen time. I know this seems like a very normal and, in some cases, unavoidable part of life, but it can and should be managed to the utmost of your ability. I know that when I spend a lot of free time on any screen, I feel disappointed with myself afterwards that I spent the time doing something like watching YouTube or playing video games instead of creating anything or checking anything off my long list of tasks. Now obviously creative or productive activities like digital art, writing, or managing finances may be discounted from this example. Manoush Zomorodi interviewed a few scientists on this topic in her (2017) Ted Talk "How Boredom Can Lead to Your Most Brilliant Ideas." She says that a couple of the things they mentioned were that large amounts of screen time can: Limit our creativity, stress out and deplete our neural resources, and increase our anxiety and stress. These are all things to keep in mind while reading my last point.

We've probably all heard the term "iPad kids" before but what does it refer to? According to Abbas, S. (2024, para. 1.), "The term "iPad kids" has been used to describe a new generation of mobile device users, most of whom use tablets or iPads over other devices such as laptops." I'm sure you've seen these kids in stores and out in public and shaken your head to yourself. Now what does this habit do to these kids? And how common is this problem? According to Dimovski, A. (2022, para 21 and 25.) "On average, kids in the US get phones or tablets when they are ten years old... One in four kids globally uses their phone in an unhealthy manner." So one quarter of kids all over the world already have this unhealthy habit. Also, based on the

average in the US, almost every ten year old kid has the phone or tablet to develop it with.

According to Walker, S. K. (2022) His research showed that excessive TV watching reduces language, cognition, and socioemotional development. It also increases the risk of early obesity and sleep issues. For babies, a focus on screens can negatively affect babies' need for reciprocal interaction, negatively affecting their language learning, sense of self, and executive functioning. So in summary, this issue is very prevalent and the effects can be really damaging for kids, especially their learning and development at a young age.

What can we do about these technology abuses? Bounds, D. (2024, para. 17.) stated that one of the best things we can do to deal with social media or screen addiction is to "Find fulfillment and happiness outside of social media." Now you know that social media and screen use can cause you all kinds of harm especially for kids. You know what you can do to start fixing the problem and spend less time on screens and on social media. With this information, you need to decide for yourself if you could have more peace and joy in your life from fixing your technology habits and spending more time with those around you.

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